

To Love

A Gateway from Human Love to Love of God

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"And it shall come to pass, if you shall listen diligently to My commandments which I command you this day, to love the LORD your God and to serve Him with all your heart and with all your soul..." [Deut. 11:13]

A.

Love of God appears as the foundation of the service of God to which we are commanded. Maimonides counts the commandment to love God as the third positive commandment, immediately after the obligation to recognize the reality and the oneness of the Creator. Throughout the book of Deuteronomy, Moses our teacher stresses to us that it is not enough to fulfill the commandments with the limbs of the body alone; we must also engage, in doing so, the best of our inner, emotional world — to love, to fear, to cleave, to serve Him with all our heart and all our soul and all our might. In Jewish thought, love of the Creator, blessed be He, is pictured as the crowning achievement of this inner work.

Many have asked, and go on asking, how it is possible to command feelings, how a person can be obligated to a specific movement or experience on the plane of his inner life. I do not share this difficulty. My own experience of existence teaches me that there is a large space of choice even within the emotional world — a person can confront certain feelings, can arouse or dampen certain sensations, can develop a way of thinking and a way of perceiving reality that stimulates inner experiences of various kinds, and so on. The question with which the commandment to love God confronts me is a different one: what, in fact, is it even about — what is love of God? How can we truly understand this concept? How could one ever point to some feeling and say: this is love of God?

The religious person undergoes many experiences bound up with his religiosity. A great many of them can be tied to the concept called love of God, so that love of God can be colored by an entire world of feelings, by countless shades of sensation, by a broad range of life experiences — much as interpersonal love, too, carries upon it a whole array of emotional points, and far beyond that: since God is revealed in different and even polarized appearances, an encounter with Him can take many and varied forms. Love of God should not be reduced to a single picture, a single emotional possibility. The richness of the concept is an inseparable part of its vitality, of its all-encompassing essence. Here I will sketch one particular path toward love of God, one particular way through which it can be grasped, understood and touched — but in no way do I mean to say that this is the only path, or even the primary path, if such a thing exists at

all. It is one option, one path among many good ones, which indeed seem to arrive at the same destination, but which — like the other paths — also colors that destination in its own distinctive hue.

B.

The concept of love, like all feelings, we first come to know from its human context. For us, love describes a certain range — sharing a decisive common denominator — of interpersonal bonds: a parent's love for a child, a child's love for parents, love between siblings, love between friends, and so on. Love with a capital L, the relationship crowned among us as the ultimate love, is the love between a man and a woman, romantic love. Love of God should be colored by the hues of these feelings, and above all by romantic love; there is, of course, room to let it be adorned with shades unique to itself, and it likely plays upon additional deep strings of the soul as well — but its foundation must resemble, decisively, interpersonal love in general and romantic, couple's love in particular. Otherwise there would be no justification for calling this religious feeling "love" at all.

One of the things that happens when we fall in love is the sense that we have found in the other something that is beyond — beyond what we find in other people, beyond even what we ourselves saw in that same person before we fell in love; beyond, in fact, what appears before our eyes at all. Standing before the beloved raises a powerful sense of mystery together with presence, a feeling of an inner meeting with layers the other has not exposed to me, as though I am catching the scent of his one-time uniqueness, the particular originality of his personality, his deep, hidden, undisclosable "I." In our eyes, the beloved is someone without equal anywhere in the world — and although we know, in sober, rational knowledge, that every person in the world is singular and unique, only in love are we overwhelmed by this clear insight, seized and enchanted by it.[1]

Love and trust descend from heaven bound together — the loving gaze includes within it trust in the basic goodness of the one who stands before us, in the infinite depth of his personality, in his exclusivity, in his hidden abilities and powers. At the root of love is sown a belief that in this person there is something worth loving. This is not necessarily a belief that he is good in a moral sense, beautiful in an aesthetic sense, or sublime in a spiritual sense. This goodness that I find within the person I love does not necessarily translate into other systems of judgment — it is goodness in the sense that I feel love toward him, I feel that he has worth, that there is uniqueness and enchantment in him, that there is justification for his existence and that it is better that he exist than not.

In religious language it seems right to describe this state as an encounter of the lover with the soul (neshama) of the beloved. In every interpersonal interaction we sense that before us stands a person who possesses a soul — that is, a living being who carries within him more than what appears outwardly, and even more than could ever come to expression in reality. But in love this sense sharpens greatly, until its reality dazzles and blinds. The infinite depth, the absolute

uniqueness, the pure, sweet goodness — all these characterize the contact with what lies beyond the visible, everyday layer of a person's soul, the contact with his neshama. I think this explains why love feels so blinding, to the point of an irrational blindness to the beloved's flaws. This is not a blindness to truth; there are not really traits of the soul left outside the lover's field of vision — it is simply that the shining light of the neshama, that is, of the person's pure divine potential, which we are not accustomed to being exposed to in an ordinary way, causes the "small details" of the actual, of the person as he is in practice, to pale and lose their relative importance.

The neshama, it is important to stress, is not some pale, abstract concept. It is not some a-priori metaphysical assumption, derived from religious dogma, about the divinity or the root goodness of every person simply by virtue of being a person. The neshama can easily be experienced as a phenomenological concept, one that describes precisely those very experiences I spoke of above. These experiences exceed the ordinary emotional charge of social life, and therefore justify a new concept — one that describes a deeper, more sublime and more hidden layer than "the psyche" or "the personality." Not only is the concept justified; it is important. The feeling of love is bound tightly to that loving gaze we described as an encounter with the soul — but this gaze does not always rise consciously to the surface, and it is a contemplation that can be undertaken deliberately, for as long as the love is still there. Especially in long-term relationships, it is important to return, again and again, the magic and the mystery of the other, the sense of the ungraspable core of his whole being. To remember that the person I have known all these years, who is revealed to me through behaviors and words and shared experiences and feelings and wishes, is in fact far beyond all of these things. And to remember that my love for him is not focused only on all that I know of him, but is rooted also — and above all — in what I do not know, in the kernel of secret that remains beneath the surface, in the obscure infinity of the depth of his being.

C.

Let us return to our subject. The question I posed at the head of this essay — what is love of God, and how can we understand this concept — is a question that also has a theological face. Can we picture a love whose object — God — evades, and not by accident, all grasp and conceptualization? Can one "love" without knowing "what"?

Let me elaborate a little on this difficulty. On a simple view, we assign the feeling of love to the group of feelings we might call relational feelings. Relational feelings are feelings we feel toward some object, a person or a thing. Unlike feelings such as joy, loneliness, weariness or depression, relational feelings will always be defined in relation to something, with reference to something. It would be meaningless to say a sentence like — "these past few days I've been feeling compassion" — without there being some object of that compassion. The same holds for anger, empathy, concern, identification, and likewise for hatred and love. These are feelings that do not designate our psychic state in itself, at some given moment, but rather the relationship between us and some object existing outside us, the inner arousal that our encounter with that

object produces within us. Naturally, the character of such feelings cannot be fully clarified without our clarifying and clearly pointing to their object. When a person feels angry, he first needs to clarify at whom or at what he is angry; when a person is worried, he needs to clarify what he is worried about; and in other cases, like compassion or hatred or love, the object leaps to the eye and is self-evident, to the point that it is hard to imagine a state in which the feeling exists within us without our being entirely clear as to whom it is directed.

It is thus understandable why Maimonides places the commandments of knowing God — belief in His existence and belief in His unity — before the commandment of love. And so he writes:

And the third commandment is that He commanded us to love Him, exalted be He. This means that we contemplate and comprehend His commandments and His works, until we grasp Him and delight in that grasp as much as possible — and this is the love that is required. And the language of the Sifrei: "Since it is said, 'and you shall love the LORD your God' — I do not know how one is to love the Omnipresent? Scripture therefore teaches, 'and these words which I command you today shall be upon your heart' — for through this you come to recognize Him who spoke and the world came into being." Thus it has already been explained to you that through contemplation, comprehension is verified for you, delight arrives, and love necessarily follows.

Sefer HaMitzvot, Positive Commandment 3

In Maimonides' words here one can find a rationale for placing the commandments of knowledge before the commandment of love: knowledge of God and comprehension of Him are the stage that leads to love, the means toward it. But there is clearly also a more basic rationale — without comprehension, the very concept of "love of God" could have no meaning at all. Comprehension does not merely advance and strengthen love, and not merely constitute it, but first of all makes it possible in the logical, theoretical sense. In order to love, we must know what to love. In order for us to love God, we must have some "picture" of Him; there must be some content, definition, filling or referent for that word, for the concept of divinity.

Here lies the real tangle — for we have no such positive definition of the divine; we cannot have one, and we must not have one. The Holy One warns us in His Torah: "Take therefore good heed unto yourselves, for you saw no manner of form" (Deut. 4:15). The medieval sages developed this warning into a broad conception, according to which the only attributes within our power and our right to grant to God are those that negate from Him defined, delimiting content. According to these sages, advancement in the comprehension of God happens through the ever-increasing internalization of more and more "negative attributes":

One who asks may ask and say: If there is no device for grasping the truth of His essence, and the demonstrative proof teaches that what is grasped is only that He exists, and that positive attributes are impossible, as has been demonstrated by proof — in what, then, does the difference in rank between those who grasp Him

consist? [...] Know, then, that this is indeed so: the difference in rank between those who apprehend is very great. For with every increase in the attributes ascribed to the described thing, it becomes more particular, and the describer draws nearer to a grasp of its true reality. Likewise, the more you add in negation regarding Him, exalted be He, the closer you come to apprehension, and you are nearer to it than one who has not negated of Him that whose negation has been demonstrated to you by proof.

Guide of the Perplexed, I:59

If this is so — if, to paraphrase, the goal of knowing the Holy One is "that we should not know" — how are we supposed to arrive at feelings of love toward this obscure object? How is the utterly indescribable image of the Holy One supposed to arouse in us any sort of relational feeling at all?

D.

It may seem strange, at first glance, to treat love in the analytical, intellectual way I am openly doing in this essay. Love should be sung, not philosophized about — so some would say. On the other hand, philosophical discussions of love have a long and distinguished history. In Plato's dialogue the Symposium, the guests at the banquet are invited to speak, one after another, in praise of Eros, the Greek god of love and desire. Socrates, the most important of the speakers, teaches us in his speech — in the name of a wise woman he once met, named Diotima — an intriguing lesson on the nature of love.

First and foremost, one must internalize that desire, that is, Eros, is not born out of some particular object, some specific object. Desire is a trait that characterizes the person who loves, and it is an expression of a lack present within him. A person who is not, himself, beautiful, good and perfect, but who has an aspiration to be joined and to cleave to beauty, goodness and perfection, desires everything in which he finds these qualities. Out of this understanding, a person is able to momentarily detach his eyes from the object of his desire, to examine the essence of his own desire, and then return his gaze to the world and discover that the very same good quality he desires can also be found and discovered in other objects. As he contemplates many other objects and discovers in them that same beauty and goodness for which his soul yearns, he in fact performs a process of generalization and abstraction — from now on he can see, in his mind's eye, that the true object of his love is not some concrete thing, some particular person or work of art, but an Idea, an absolute spiritual object that directly reflects the essential lack at the base of his desires.

According to Diotima, the domain of desire's objects — that is, the world — is revealed to human desire dialectically, stage by stage, from the low to the high, from the concrete to the abstract, from the material to the spiritual — an ascent up a ladder. This unfolding of the world in this manner is the fruit of the understanding of a lover who manages to love without being dependent on his love's object — a

lover who understands, from the outset, that what draws him in the object of his desire is, in principle, also present in other possible objects. Thus, when a lover pursuing the beauty of soul of his beloved understands that the beauty that draws him is in fact also present in other objects, he sets out on a search that leads, through the beauty of those other objects, to a dimension that lies beyond beauty of soul-and-personality altogether — to beauty and goodness in themselves; and so, once the lover understands that what makes a particular soul beautiful is not to be found in that soul itself, he will continue his search for an encounter with the very Idea of beauty and goodness itself...

Vered Lev-Kenaan and Hagi Kenaan, "Eros in Plato's Symposium"[2]

The cognitive process described here — of generalization and abstraction — is not some cold, rational process of analysis. Since this contemplation deals with inner emotional fibers, with a heart pierced by love, with sensitive and deep strands of the soul, the journey of contemplation, too, is an emotional journey, one that passes indeed through the realms of theoretical thought, but no less through the realm of imagination and experience. Imagination, serving as the vehicle for carrying out this cognitive generalization, is a wide emotional conduit that pours emotional charge from one thing to another, from object to object, from a concrete instance to an ideal spiritual concept. Hence, the endpoint of the process of abstraction described, in which the lover "goes out onto the open sea of beauty and gazes upon it,"[3] is described by Plato as an illumination, a wondrous and uplifting vision after which life does not go back to being what it was. As if all the specific rivers of love and beauty, flowing through our hearts from every corner of the land of the living, all drain together into that same "open sea," an infinite ocean, a single glimpse into which brings a sense of wonder and grandeur, filling our heart to overflowing with admiration and the flame of love.

E.

It seems that we can deal with the problems we have raised by way of Diotima's counsel. If we climb the ladder of love, moving from the real, concrete objects of love that we know from life toward the abstract Idea of their "beauty," we can arrive at the gates of love of God. What opens up love of God for us as a real, lived experience are our natural loves, and, at the summit of them all, the romantic love between a man and a woman.

God testifies of us that we were created in His image. The human soul is the candle of God, and it is breathed from the spirit of God. Within every person there is an inner kernel, hidden and concealed, which is a part of the divine from above, a spark of that supernal infinity that is inaccessible to us in any definition or comprehension. The divinity of the human soul does not explain only the human, but also the divine. It contributes to us not only an understanding of the sense of wonder at standing before another person, of the feeling that we stand before something hidden that is pure and radiant regardless of what can be seen emerging from it; it not only clarifies for us the source of the power of the wish for companionship and the search

for love, the great power of these to dazzle us and drive us to step outside ourselves to the point of madness — but, in addition, these very feelings, in turn, teach us about the divine matter, and color its face with real emotional lines the likes of which nothing else can offer. In place of a collection of theoretical attributes drawn from the philosophical lexicon, our conceptualization of the divine concept suddenly gains color and scent, volume and life. Words like "infinity," "absolute goodness" or "nobility" suddenly take on real content and meaning, a meaning well rooted in our emotional world and in the context of our lives, in the field of our deepest encounter with other human beings, and in particular with our heart's beloved. Out of this, a familiar emotional form of love of God is sketched for us as well.

Human love is not only an explanation for love of God, but also the way toward it — not only the "what," but also the "how." The Diotima-style contemplation causes us to abstract that very sublime wonder we encountered in our beloved — which is the "what" that we love in him, the hidden, essential and root goodness within him — and to see it as something that exists in its own right, something whose existence is general and that merely appears and is revealed through the particular beloved person in whom we encountered it. In this way we come to understand that we love God. For He is the source of life, He is the Rock from which the souls of all who come into the world are hewn, He stands at the root of the unique, mysterious spark with which we fell in love. Our love for a particular person, and likewise our loves, to some degree, for other people as well, are all rivers issuing forth and flowing from the Eden-spring of the deep love of God in our hearts.

This picture of love of God, born out of love of a person, does not stand in contradiction to the doctrine of negative attributes. On the contrary — despite all this talk of the "beauty" of soul of the person we love, standing before the soul of my beloved brings me not to a sense of grasp and comprehensive apprehension of his entire essence, but, to a great extent, to the opposite feeling as well. Even though love does indeed carry a deep dimension of knowing the other, this knowledge shares certain qualities with the knowledge of God — for the essence of this knowledge is the sense of wonder and enchantment, the feeling that there is something here I cannot fully grasp. There is an encounter, a certain contact — touching and not touching — with the inner essence of my beloved, but the summit of the encounter lies in the lucid recognition that not everything is accessible to me, that there is something here that, even as it enchants me and captivates my heart, stands entirely in its own right, and one cannot get to the bottom of its essence. This sense of wonder and enchantment is itself the content of the Idea of "beauty of soul" that I abstract out of my love, and it is, therefore, itself the content of my comprehension of God and my love of God.

"And you shall love your neighbor as yourself" — Rabbi Akiva says: this is a great principle of the Torah. Ben Azzai says: "This is the book of the generations of Adam [on the day that God created man, in the likeness of God He made him]" — this is a principle even greater than that one.

Notes

1. I find beautiful the words of Viktor Frankl: "Love is the only way to grasp another human being in the innermost core of his personality. No one can become fully aware of the very essence of another human being unless he loves him. By his love he is enabled to see the essential traits and features in the beloved person; and even more, he sees that which is potential in him, which is not yet actualized but yet ought to be actualized." (Viktor Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning*, p. 135 [of the Hebrew edition]).
2. Printed as an appendix together with: Plato, *Symposium*, trans. from Greek by Margalit Finkelberg, p. 138, Hargol Publishing, Tel Aviv, 2001.
3. *Symposium*, p. 88.